A Year at the Kestrel Valley School

Kestrel Valley School sits at the end of a gravel road, two hours from the nearest town. It has forty-one pupils, three teachers and a cook who also drives the school bus. Most families in the valley raise sheep or work at the timber mill.

Lessons follow the national curriculum, but the setting shapes every subject. The headteacher likes to say that every child here learns to read the river before they read a map. In spring the older pupils measure the water level each morning and record it on a chart in the hall. The data has been shared with the regional flood office for six years.

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Winter brings its own timetable. When snow closes the road, lessons move online and the teachers call each family in turn. The school hopes to install a small weather station before next autumn.